

Jeremiah 40 - 42

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight we watch what happens after the worst has already happened - which is its own kind of test, and one the remnant fails.

A prophet standing in chains at a staging camp, offered his freedom by a Babylonian officer.

A decent governor who was warned about the man who would murder him, and would not believe it.

Eighty pilgrims with shaved beards and torn clothes, met on the road by a man weeping as he walked toward them.

Ten days of silence while a whole community waits for an answer they have already decided to ignore.

Jeremiah 40 gives the remnant everything it needs - a governor, a harvest, a policy, and the prophet himself - and lets one man's refusal to believe a warning undo all of it.

Jeremiah 41 is the ugliest chapter in the book: murder at a shared table, a massacre of worshipers, and a cistern filled with bodies.

Jeremiah 42 records the most explicit promise-and-breach in Scripture - a vow made under oath and broken within a fortnight.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 40 - Freed at Ramah, and a Warning Refused

Key Notes

- Jeremiah is found in chains at Ramah, the staging camp where deportees were sorted - the same Ramah where chapter 31 heard Rachel weeping (Jeremiah 40:1).
- Nebuzaradan's speech is startling on a Babylonian officer's lips: Yahweh pronounced this, Yahweh brought it, and it happened because you sinned against Him (Jeremiah 40:2-3).
- The pagan captain articulates Judah's own covenant theology more accurately than most of Judah's prophets had managed (Jeremiah 40:3).
- Jeremiah is given a genuinely free choice - Babylon with protection and patronage, or anywhere in the land he likes - and no pressure either way (Jeremiah 40:4).
- He chooses the rubble. Given the option of comfort in the imperial capital, he goes to Mizpah to live among the poorest survivors (Jeremiah 40:5-6).
- Gedaliah is a good appointment from a good family - grandson of Shaphan, son of the Ahikam who saved Jeremiah's life - and his policy is exactly right (Jeremiah 40:7-9).
- "Don't be afraid to serve the Chaldeans. Dwell in the land... and it will be well with you" is Jeremiah's own message, now spoken by a governor (Jeremiah 40:9).
- For a brief moment it works. Jews scattered in Moab, Ammon, and Edom hear there is a remnant and come home, and gather a very large harvest of wine and summer fruit (Jeremiah 40:11-12).
- This is the closest thing to restoration in the whole book - people returning voluntarily, harvesting, living under a just administrator, with the prophet among them (Jeremiah 40:12).
- Then Johanan brings a specific, sourced warning: Baalis king of Ammon has sent Ishmael to assassinate you (Jeremiah 40:13-14).
- Gedaliah does not investigate, does not increase his guard, and does not confront Ishmael. He simply does not believe it (Jeremiah 40:14).
- Johanan offers to handle it quietly, and frames the stakes precisely: why should the whole remnant be scattered over one man? He is refused and accused of slander (Jeremiah 40:15-16).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
A Pagan Officer Confessing Yahweh's Hand	Jeremiah 40:2-3 • Joshua 2:9-11 • Daniel 4:34-35
"All the Land Is Before You"	Jeremiah 40:4 • Genesis 13:9 • Jeremiah 39:12
Gedaliah Made Governor	Jeremiah 40:5 • Jeremiah 39:14 • 2 Kings 25:22
Mizpah as a Gathering Place	Jeremiah 40:6 • Jeremiah 42:10 • Judges 20:1
The Remnant Left in the Land	Jeremiah 40:7 • 2 Kings 25:23-24 • Jeremiah 39:10

Topic	References
Serve Babylon and Live	Jeremiah 40:9 • Jeremiah 27:11 • Jeremiah 38:17
Build, Plant, and Gather the Harvest	Jeremiah 40:10 • Jeremiah 29:5-7 • Amos 9:14
A Warning Given and Dismissed	Jeremiah 40:14 • Proverbs 22:3 • Nehemiah 6:10-13

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
True Words in an Unlikely Mouth	Jeremiah 40:2 • John 11:49-52 • Mark 15:39
Choosing the Rubble Over the Palace	Jeremiah 40:6 • Hebrews 11:24-26 • Philippians 2:6-7
Submission That Preserves Life	Jeremiah 40:9 • Matthew 11:29 • 1 Peter 5:6
The Scattered Coming Home	Jeremiah 40:12 • Jeremiah 40:11 • Isaiah 11:11-12
Wise as Serpents, Harmless as Doves	Jeremiah 40:16 • Proverbs 14:15 • Matthew 10:16
A Shepherd Who Would Not See the Wolf	Jeremiah 40:14 • John 10:12-13 • Acts 20:29-31

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 40 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - Jeremiah's release at Ramah, Gedaliah's brief governorship, and the warning he refused
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 40](#) - the post-fall remnant and the administration at Mizpah in its historical setting
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 40](#) - exposition of Jeremiah's choice to remain with the poor rather than accept Babylonian patronage

Jeremiah 40 - Opening Intro

Two decisions define this chapter, and they run in opposite directions.

The first is Jeremiah's. He is standing in a chain gang at Ramah when a Babylonian officer recognizes him and cuts him loose. The offer is real: come to Babylon and I will personally look after you. For a man in his sixties who has been beaten, jailed, and left to sink in a cistern by his own countrymen, imperial patronage in a functioning city is not a small thing.

He goes to Mizpah instead - to a burned-out province, to the poorest people left alive, to live among a remnant that had never once listened to him. Forty years of being ignored, and given the chance to leave, he stays.

Notice too who says the truest theology in the chapter. Not a priest, not a prophet - Nebuzaradan, captain of the Babylonian guard: Yahweh said this would happen, Yahweh did it, and it happened because you sinned against Him. A career soldier from an idolatrous empire gives a more accurate account of the fall of Jerusalem than Judah's own religious establishment managed in forty years.

The second decision is Gedaliah's, and it destroys everything. He is a good man - his policy is sound, his family is honorable, and under him people actually start coming home. Verse 12 is the closest thing to a happy paragraph in this entire book: Jews returning from Moab and Ammon and Edom, gathering a very great harvest.

And then Johanan tells him, with a name and a sponsor attached, that Ishmael is coming to kill him. Gedaliah does not investigate. He does not post a guard. He tells Johanan he is lying.

It is worth being careful here, because the failure is not that Gedaliah was trusting. Trust is a virtue. The failure is that he treated a credible, specific warning as slander and took no precaution at all - and he was not the only one who paid for it. Johanan's question in verse 15 turns out to be exactly the right one: why should the whole remnant be scattered over one man?

Before we read, hold both men. One gave up safety he could have taken. The other kept a generosity he could not afford. Discernment is not cynicism, and being good is not the same as being careful.

Jeremiah 40:1-16 (WEB)

1 The word which came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, after Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard had let him go from Ramah, when he had taken him being bound in chains among all the captives of Jerusalem and Judah, who were carried away captive to Babylon.

2 The captain of the guard took Jeremiah, and said to him, "Yahweh your God pronounced this evil on this place;^{1,2}

3 and Yahweh has brought it, and done according as he spoke. Because you have sinned against Yahweh, and have not obeyed his voice, therefore this thing has come on you.

4 Now, behold, I release you today from the chains which are on your hand. If it seems good to you to come with me into Babylon, come, and I will take care of you; but if it seems bad to you to come with me into Babylon, don't. Behold, all the land is before you. Where it seems good and right to you to go, there go."³

5 Now while he had not yet gone back, "Go back then," he said, "to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan, whom the king of Babylon has made governor over the cities of Judah, and dwell with him

¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Joshua 2:9-11](#) • [Daniel 4:34-35](#) - Rahab and Nebuchadnezzar - outsiders who named Yahweh's hand more clearly than Israel did

² **Messianic Connection:** [John 11:49-52](#) • [Mark 15:39](#) - Caiaphas prophesying without knowing it, and a centurion confessing at the cross

³ **Cross-Reference:** [Genesis 13:9](#) • [Jeremiah 39:12](#) - the whole land set before a man to choose, and the order to do him no harm

among the people; or go wherever it seems right to you to go.” So the captain of the guard gave him food and a present, and let him go.⁴

6 Then Jeremiah went to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam to Mizpah, and lived with him among the people who were left in the land.⁵

7 Now when all the captains of the forces who were in the fields, even they and their men, heard that the king of Babylon had made Gedaliah the son of Ahikam governor in the land, and had committed to him men, women, children, and of the poorest of the land, of those who were not carried away captive to Babylon;⁶

8 then Ishmael the son of Nethaniah, and Johanan and Jonathan the sons of Kareah, and Seraiah the son of Tanhumeth, and the sons of Ephai the Netophathite, and Jezaniah the son of the Maacathite, they and their men came to Gedaliah to Mizpah.

9 Gedaliah the son of Ahikam the son of Shaphan swore to them and to their men, saying, “Don’t be afraid to serve the Chaldeans. Dwell in the land, and serve the king of Babylon, and it will be well with you.”^{7,8}

10 As for me, behold, I will dwell at Mizpah, to stand before the Chaldeans who will come to us; but you, gather wine and summer fruits and oil, and put them in your vessels, and dwell in your cities that you have taken.”⁹

11 Likewise when all the Jews who were in Moab, and among the children of Ammon, and in Edom, and who were in all the countries, heard that the king of Babylon had left a remnant of Judah, and that he had set over them Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan;

12 then all the Jews returned out of all places where they were driven, and came to the land of Judah, to Gedaliah, to Mizpah, and gathered very much wine and summer fruits.¹⁰

13 Moreover Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the captains of the forces who were in the fields, came to Gedaliah to Mizpah,

⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 39:14](#) • [2 Kings 25:22](#) - Gedaliah son of Ahikam appointed governor over those left in the land

⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 42:10](#) • [Judges 20:1](#) - the promise to build them if they stay, and Mizpah as Israel’s old assembly place

⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [2 Kings 25:23-24](#) • [Jeremiah 39:10](#) - the captains coming in, and the poor who had been given fields and vineyards

⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 27:11](#) • [Jeremiah 38:17](#) - the nation that brings its neck under the yoke stays on its land

⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 11:29](#) • [1 Peter 5:6](#) - taking His yoke, and humbling ourselves under the mighty hand of God

⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 29:5-7](#) • [Amos 9:14](#) - build houses, plant gardens, gather the fruit - ordinary life as obedience

¹⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 40:11](#) • [Isaiah 11:11-12](#) - the scattered hearing there is a remnant, and the outcasts assembled from the nations

14 and said to him, “Do you know that Baalis the king of the children of Ammon has sent Ishmael the son of Nethaniah to take your life?” But Gedaliah the son of Ahikam didn’t believe them.¹¹

15 Then Johanan the son of Kareah spoke to Gedaliah in Mizpah secretly, saying, “Please let me go, and I will kill Ishmael the son of Nethaniah, and no man will know it. Why should he take your life, that all the Jews who are gathered to you should be scattered, and the remnant of Judah perish?”

16 But Gedaliah the son of Ahikam said to Johanan the son of Kareah, “You shall not do this thing; for you speak falsely of Ishmael.”¹²

¹¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Proverbs 22:3](#) • [Nehemiah 6:10-13](#) - the prudent man foreseeing evil and hiding himself, and a warning that had to be weighed

¹² **Cross-Reference:** [Proverbs 14:15](#) • [Matthew 10:16](#) - the simple believes every word, and the call to be wise as serpents and harmless as doves

CHAPTER 41 - Murder at Mizpah

Key Notes

- Ishmael is identified as royal seed - a descendant of the Davidic house - which supplies the motive the text never states outright: a claimant murdering an administrator (Jeremiah 41:1).
- He comes with ten men and they eat bread together at Mizpah. The murder happens at a shared table, which in that culture made it a violation of hospitality as well as of life (Jeremiah 41:1-2).
- The victim was Babylon's appointee, so Ishmael also kills the Chaldean garrison - guaranteeing imperial reprisal against everyone who remains (Jeremiah 41:3).
- For two days nobody outside Mizpah knows. The narrative pauses on that silence before it gets worse (Jeremiah 41:4).
- Eighty pilgrims arrive from Shechem, Shiloh, and Samaria - northern towns, still bringing offerings toward a temple that has been ash for two months (Jeremiah 41:5).
- Their shaved beards, torn clothes, and self-inflicted cuts are mourning rites, some of them Torah-forbidden, but the grief behind them is real (Jeremiah 41:5).
- Ishmael goes out to meet them weeping as he walks - performing their own sorrow back at them in order to get them inside the gate (Jeremiah 41:6).
- Seventy of the eighty are killed in the middle of the city and thrown into a cistern. Ten buy their lives with hidden stores of wheat, barley, oil, and honey (Jeremiah 41:7-8).
- The cistern is identified as one King Asa dug three centuries earlier as a defensive work - a waterworks built to preserve life, filled with the dead (Jeremiah 41:9).
- Ishmael takes the survivors captive, including the king's daughters, and heads for Ammon - toward Baalis, the sponsor named in the warning Gedaliah dismissed (Jeremiah 41:10).
- Johanan catches him at the great waters of Gibeon. The captives simply change sides and walk back, and Ishmael escapes with eight men (Jeremiah 41:11-15).
- The rescued remnant does not go home. They camp at Geruth Chimham near Bethlehem, planning to flee to Egypt, afraid of Chaldean reprisal (Jeremiah 41:16-18).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Murder at a Shared Table	Jeremiah 41:1 • 2 Samuel 20:9-10 • Psalm 41:9
The Assassination of Gedaliah	Jeremiah 41:2 • 2 Kings 25:25 • Jeremiah 40:14
Shaved Beards and Cut Flesh	Jeremiah 41:5 • Leviticus 19:27-28 • Deuteronomy 14:1
Tears Used as a Weapon	Jeremiah 41:6 • Proverbs 26:24-25 • Psalm 55:21
Lying in Wait for Blood	Jeremiah 41:7 • Micah 7:2 • Psalm 10:8-9
Asa's Cistern at Mizpah	Jeremiah 41:9 • 1 Kings 15:22 • 2 Chronicles 16:6

Topic	References
The Remnant Carried Off	Jeremiah 41:10 • Jeremiah 39:10 • Jeremiah 40:7
Johanan Leads the Survivors	Jeremiah 41:16 • Jeremiah 40:13 • Jeremiah 42:1

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Betrayer's Hand at the Table	Jeremiah 41:1 • Luke 22:21 • John 13:26-27
Worshippers Killed on the Way to Worship	Jeremiah 41:5-7 • Luke 13:1 • Matthew 23:35
A Pit Meant for Water, Filled With the Dead	Jeremiah 41:9 • Jeremiah 2:13 • Genesis 37:24
Fleeing Toward Egypt in Fear	Jeremiah 41:17 • Matthew 2:13-15 • Isaiah 30:2
Fearing Man Instead of Trusting God	Jeremiah 41:18 • Jeremiah 42:11 • Isaiah 51:12-13
Near Bethlehem, and Weeping Again	Jeremiah 41:17 • Jeremiah 31:15 • Matthew 2:18

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 41 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the assassination, the massacre of the pilgrims, and Johanan's pursuit to Gibeon
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 41](#) - the Gedaliah assassination and the fast of the seventh month observed since
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 41](#) - exposition of how one refused warning unraveled the entire post-exilic remnant

Jeremiah 41 - Opening Intro

This is the darkest chapter in Jeremiah, and it contains no oracle at all. No "thus says Yahweh," no prophetic commentary, no interpretation. Just a sequence of events reported flatly, the way a police file reads.

Ishmael is royal seed - a Davidide - and that single detail supplies everything the text leaves unsaid. A man with a claim to the throne is watching a commoner from a scribal family govern Judah on Babylon's authority. He is also, according to chapter 40, on the payroll of the king of Ammon. Wounded dynastic pride and foreign money are a reliably lethal combination.

He murders Gedaliah at a meal. In the ancient Near East that is not merely killing; eating together created an obligation, and violating it was its own category of crime. It is the same horror the psalmist means by "my own familiar friend, who ate bread with me."

Then verse 5 arrives and the chapter goes somewhere worse. Eighty men come down from Shechem and Shiloh and Samaria - northern territory, not even Judah - with beards shaved and clothes torn, carrying grain offerings and frankincense. They are walking toward a temple that has been rubble for two months. Either the news had not reached them, or they were coming to grieve at the site anyway. Either way, these are the most sincerely religious people in the chapter.

And Ishmael walks out to meet them crying. He mimics their grief to bring them inside the walls, and then kills seventy of them and throws the bodies into a cistern.

The detail about the cistern is the one that stays with you. It was dug by King Asa three hundred years earlier as part of fortifying Mizpah - a water system, infrastructure for keeping people alive under siege. It ends up as a mass grave. That is what this chapter is: things built to preserve life turned to the opposite use.

Before we read, notice where the survivors end up. Not back at Mizpah. Camped near Bethlehem, packing for Egypt, running from a punishment that had not been announced. The whole remnant is about to make its worst decision, and the reason is fear - not of God, but of consequences they assumed and never verified.

Jeremiah 41:1-18 (WEB)

1 Now in the seventh month, Ishmael the son of Nethaniah, the son of Elishama, of the royal offspring and one of the chief officers of the king, and ten men with him, came to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam to Mizpah; and there they ate bread together in Mizpah. ^{13,14}

2 Then Ishmael the son of Nethaniah arose, and the ten men who were with him, and struck Gedaliah the son of Ahikam the son of Shaphan with the sword and killed him, whom the king of Babylon had made governor over the land. ¹⁵

3 Ishmael also killed all the Jews who were with him, with Gedaliah, at Mizpah, and the Chaldeans who were found there, the men of war.

4 The second day after he had killed Gedaliah, and no man knew it,

5 men came from Shechem, from Shiloh, and from Samaria, even eighty men, having their beards shaved and their clothes torn, and having cut themselves, with meal offerings and frankincense in their hand, to bring them to Yahweh's house. ¹⁶

¹³ **Cross-Reference:** [2 Samuel 20:9-10](#) • [Psalm 41:9](#) - *Joab's greeting before the sword, and the familiar friend who ate bread and lifted his heel*

¹⁴ **Messianic Connection:** [Luke 22:21](#) • [John 13:26-27](#) - *the hand of the betrayer with Him on the table, and the morsel given at supper*

¹⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [2 Kings 25:25](#) • [Jeremiah 40:14](#) - *the same murder recorded in Kings, and the warning that named the man in advance*

¹⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 19:27-28](#) • [Deuteronomy 14:1](#) - *the mourning customs Torah restricted - grief expressed in forbidden forms is still grief*

6 Ishmael the son of Nethaniah went out from Mizpah to meet them, weeping all along as he went: and as he met them, he said to them, "Come to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam."¹⁷

7 It was so, when they came into the middle of the city, that Ishmael the son of Nethaniah killed them, and cast them into the middle of the pit, he, and the men who were with him.¹⁸

8 But ten men were found among those who said to Ishmael, "Don't kill us; for we have stores hidden in the field, of wheat, and of barley, and of oil, and of honey." So he stopped, and didn't kill them among their brothers.

9 Now the pit in which Ishmael cast all the dead bodies of the men whom he had killed, by the side of Gedaliah (the same was that which Asa the king had made for fear of Baasha king of Israel), Ishmael the son of Nethaniah filled it with those who were killed.¹⁹

10 Then Ishmael carried away captive all the of the people who were left in Mizpah, even the king's daughters, and all the people who remained in Mizpah, whom Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard had committed to Gedaliah the son of Ahikam. Ishmael the son of Nethaniah carried them away captive, and departed to go over to the children of Ammon.²⁰

11 But when Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the captains of the forces who were with him, heard of all the evil that Ishmael the son of Nethaniah had done,

12 then they took all the men, and went to fight with Ishmael the son of Nethaniah, and found him by the great waters that are in Gibeon.

13 Now when all the people who were with Ishmael saw Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the captains of the forces who were with him, then they were glad.

14 So all the people who Ishmael had carried away captive from Mizpah turned about and came back, and went to Johanan the son of Kareah.

15 But Ishmael the son of Nethaniah escaped from Johanan with eight men, and went to the children of Ammon.

16 Then Johanan the son of Kareah and all the captains of the forces who were with him took all the remnant of the people whom he had recovered from Ishmael the son of Nethaniah, from Mizpah, after he had killed Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, the men of war, with the women, the children, and the eunuchs, whom he had brought back from Gibeon.²¹

¹⁷ Cross-Reference: [Proverbs 26:24-25](#) • [Psalm 55:21](#) - the hater who disguises himself with his lips, and words smoother than butter

¹⁸ Cross-Reference: [Micah 7:2](#) • [Psalm 10:8-9](#) - every man hunting his brother with a net, lying in wait to catch the poor

¹⁹ Cross-Reference: [1 Kings 15:22](#) • [2 Chronicles 16:6](#) - Asa fortifying Mizpah - a work built to preserve life, ending as a grave

²⁰ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 39:10](#) • [Jeremiah 40:7](#) - the poorest of the land, given fields two months earlier, now taken captive again

²¹ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 40:13](#) • [Jeremiah 42:1](#) - Johanan, who was right about Ishmael, now leading the people who would not listen

17 They departed and lived in Geruth Chimham, which is by Bethlehem, to go to enter into Egypt^{22,23}

18 because of the Chaldeans; for they were afraid of them, because Ishmael the son of Nethaniah had killed Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, whom the king of Babylon made governor over the land.²⁴

²² **Cross-Reference:** [2 Samuel 19:37-38](#) • [Genesis 12:10](#) - Chimham, Barzillai's son, and the old reflex of going down to Egypt when things get hard

²³ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 2:13-15](#) • [Isaiah 30:2](#) - one flight to Egypt commanded by God, another taken without asking Him

²⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 42:11](#) • [Isaiah 51:12-13](#) - told not to fear the king of Babylon, yet fearing a man who dies and forgetting their Maker

CHAPTER 42 - Ten Days, and a Promise Already Broken

Key Notes

- The whole community comes to Jeremiah - captains, Johanan, and all the people from the least to the greatest. Nobody is excluded from what follows (Jeremiah 42:1).
- The request is well-formed and humble: pray for us, we are few out of many, show us the way we should walk and the thing we should do (Jeremiah 42:2-3).
- Jeremiah's answer sets the standard for anyone who speaks for God: whatever He answers, I will tell you - "I will keep nothing back from you" (Jeremiah 42:4).
- They swear an oath and call Yahweh as witness against themselves, which is the most binding form of commitment available to them (Jeremiah 42:5).
- Verse 6 is the promise the chapter will measure them against: "Whether it is good, or whether it is bad, we will obey" (Jeremiah 42:6).
- Then ten days of silence. God does not answer on demand, and the delay is part of the record - long enough for the eager to become the impatient (Jeremiah 42:7).
- The answer, when it comes, is astonishingly gentle. Stay, and I will build you and plant you, "for I grieve over the distress that I have brought on you" (Jeremiah 42:10).
- God says He is sorry about what He had to do. The Hebrew is the language of relenting, of a heart moved - directed at the very people He disciplined (Jeremiah 42:10).
- Their specific fear is addressed by name: do not be afraid of the king of Babylon, for I am with you to save you and deliver you from his hand (Jeremiah 42:11).
- He promises to work on their behalf inside the mind of their enemy - "I will grant you mercy, that he may have mercy on you" (Jeremiah 42:12).
- The alternative is spelled out with precision. The sword you fear will find you in Egypt; the famine you fear will follow you there; the safety is the illusion (Jeremiah 42:14-17).
- Jeremiah then names what has already happened in their hearts: "you have dealt deceitfully against your own souls." They had decided before they asked (Jeremiah 42:20).
- The chapter closes with the verdict of the whole episode: I have declared it to you today, and you have not obeyed in anything (Jeremiah 42:21-22).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
A Third Delegation Asking for Prayer	Jeremiah 42:2 • Jeremiah 37:3 • Jeremiah 21:2
"Show Us the Way We Should Walk"	Jeremiah 42:3 • Psalm 143:8 • Isaiah 30:21
All That Yahweh Says, We Will Do	Jeremiah 42:5-6 • Deuteronomy 5:27 • Exodus 24:3
Ten Days of Waiting	Jeremiah 42:7 • Habakkuk 2:1 • Psalm 27:14

Topic	References
Build and Plant, Not Pull Down	Jeremiah 42:10 • Jeremiah 1:10 • Jeremiah 24:6
“Don’t Be Afraid of the King of Babylon”	Jeremiah 42:11 • Isaiah 41:10 • Jeremiah 1:8
The Sword Follows Them to Egypt	Jeremiah 42:16 • Jeremiah 44:12-14 • Amos 9:1-3
Do Not Go Back to Egypt	Jeremiah 42:19 • Deuteronomy 17:16 • Isaiah 31:1

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Keeping Nothing Back	Jeremiah 42:4 • John 8:26 • Acts 20:20
Saying “We Will Obey” and Not Going	Jeremiah 42:5-6 • James 1:22 • Titus 1:16
A God Who Grieves Over the Distress He Brings	Jeremiah 42:10 • Genesis 6:6 • Luke 19:41
Mercy Granted in an Enemy’s Heart	Jeremiah 42:12 • Proverbs 21:1 • Ezra 7:27-28
Deceiving Our Own Souls	Jeremiah 42:20 • James 1:26 • Hebrews 3:13
Asking for Guidance Already Decided Against	Jeremiah 42:20-21 • Luke 6:46 • Ezekiel 33:31-32

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 42 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the remnant’s oath, the ten-day delay, and the answer they had already refused
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 42](#) - the Egypt prohibition read against the Torah’s warnings about returning there
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 42](#) - exposition of seeking God’s will with a decision already made

Jeremiah 42 - Opening Intro

This chapter is about a prayer meeting that was theater, and everyone in it was sincere at the time.

Read verses 1 through 6 without knowing what comes next and it is exemplary. The whole community shows up. They are humble - “we are left but a few of many.” They ask the right question, which is not “bless our plan” but “show us the way we should walk and the thing we should do.” They swear an oath. And they add the clause that seals it: whether it is good or whether it is bad, we will obey.

You cannot ask better than that. It is the model prayer for guidance.

Then ten days pass.

That silence is not an accident of the narrative; it is the hinge of the chapter. God does not answer on the schedule of the people asking, and ten days is long enough for a resolution made in a moment of fear to start looking negotiable. Somewhere in that fortnight, the willingness curdles.

And when the answer comes, it is the most tender thing Yahweh says in the last third of this book. Stay here and I will build you and plant you - the construction verbs from chapter 1, restored. Do not be afraid of Nebuchadnezzar; I will be with you to save you. I will even work in his heart so that he shows you mercy. And then verse 10: "for I grieve over the distress that I have brought on you."

Sit with that sentence. God is expressing regret over the pain He Himself administered - not because the judgment was unjust, but because He took no pleasure in it. He is speaking to the survivors of a catastrophe He sent, and He tells them it grieved Him.

They go to Egypt anyway.

Jeremiah's diagnosis in verse 20 is precise and worth memorizing: "you have dealt deceitfully against your own souls." Not against me. Not even primarily against God. Against yourselves. They ran the whole procedure - the asking, the oath, the waiting - as a formality over a decision they had already made, and the person most damaged by that performance was the person performing it.

Before we read, ask the question this chapter is built to ask. Is there anything we are currently praying about that we have, in fact, already decided?

Jeremiah 42:1-22 (WEB)

1 Then all the captains of the forces, and Johanan the son of Kareah, and Jezaniah the son of Hoshaiah, and all the people from the least even to the greatest, came near,

2 and said to Jeremiah the prophet, "Please let our supplication be presented before you, and pray for us to Yahweh your God, even for all this remnant; for we are left but a few of many, as your eyes see us;²⁵

3 that Yahweh your God may show us the way in which we should walk, and the things that we should do."²⁶

4 Then Jeremiah the prophet said to them, "I have heard you. Behold, I will pray to Yahweh your God according to your words; and it will happen that whatever thing Yahweh answers you, I will declare it to you. I will keep nothing back from you."²⁷

²⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 37:3](#) • [Jeremiah 21:2](#) - the third time in this book that people request intercession without intending obedience

²⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 143:8](#) • [Isaiah 30:21](#) - cause me to know the way I should walk, and a voice behind you saying, this is the way

²⁷ **Messianic Connection:** [John 8:26](#) • [Acts 20:20](#) - speaking to the world what He heard from the Father, and keeping back nothing profitable

5 Then they said to Jeremiah, "May Yahweh be a true and faithful witness among us, if we don't do according to all the word with which Yahweh your God sends you to tell us."^{28,29}

6 Whether it is good, or whether it is bad, we will obey the voice of Yahweh our God, to whom we send you; that it may be well with us, when we obey the voice of Yahweh our God."

7 After ten days, Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah.³⁰

8 Then he called Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the captains of the forces who were with him, and all the people from the least even to the greatest,

9 and said to them, "Yahweh, the God of Israel, to whom you sent me to present your supplication before him, says:

10 'If you will still live in this land, then I will build you, and not pull you down, and I will plant you, and not pluck you up; for I grieve over the distress that I have brought on you.'^{31,32}

11 Don't be afraid of the king of Babylon, of whom you are afraid. Don't be afraid of him,' says Yahweh: 'for I am with you to save you, and to deliver you from his hand.'³³

12 I will grant you mercy, that he may have mercy on you, and cause you to return to your own land.

13 "'But if you say, "We will not dwell in this land;" so that you don't obey Yahweh your God's voice,

14 saying, "No; but we will go into the land of Egypt, where we will see no war, nor hear the sound of the trumpet, nor have hunger of bread; and there will we dwell:""

15 now therefore hear Yahweh's word, O remnant of Judah: Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says, 'If you indeed set your faces to enter into Egypt, and go to live there;

16 then it will happen that the sword, which you fear, will overtake you there in the land of Egypt; and the famine, about which you are afraid, will follow close behind you there in Egypt; and you will die there.'³⁴

²⁸ **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 5:27](#) • [Exodus 24:3](#) - Israel at Sinai saying all that Yahweh has spoken we will do - a vow with a long history

²⁹ **Messianic Connection:** [James 1:22](#) • [Titus 1:16](#) - hearers who deceive themselves, professing to know God but denying Him by their works

³⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Habakkuk 2:1](#) • [Psalm 27:14](#) - standing watch to see what He will say, and waiting on Yahweh with a strengthened heart

³¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 1:10](#) • [Jeremiah 24:6](#) - the building and planting verbs of the original call, offered to the remnant

³² **Messianic Connection:** [Genesis 6:6](#) • [Luke 19:41](#) - a God grieved in His heart, and a Savior weeping over the city He was about to lose

³³ **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 41:10](#) • [Jeremiah 1:8](#) - fear not, for I am with you - the promise made to the prophet now extended to the people

³⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 44:12-14](#) • [Amos 9:1-3](#) - the sword overtaking them in Egypt, and no digging deep enough to escape His hand

17 So will it be with all the men who set their faces to go into Egypt to live there. They will die by the sword, by the famine, and by the pestilence. None of them will remain or escape from the evil that I will bring on them.'

18 For Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: 'As my anger and my wrath has been poured out on the inhabitants of Jerusalem, so my wrath will be poured out on you, when you enter into Egypt; and you will be an object of horror, an astonishment, a curse, and a reproach; and you will see this place no more.'

19 "Yahweh has spoken concerning you, remnant of Judah, 'Don't go into Egypt!' Know certainly that I have testified to you today.³⁵

20 For you have dealt deceitfully against your own souls; for you sent me to Yahweh your God, saying, 'Pray for us to Yahweh our God; and according to all that Yahweh our God says, so declare to us, and we will do it.'³⁶

21 I have declared it to you today; but you have not obeyed Yahweh your God's voice in anything for which he has sent me to you.

22 Now therefore know certainly that you will die by the sword, by the famine, and by the pestilence in the place where you desire to go to live there."

³⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 17:16](#) • [Isaiah 31:1](#) - the king forbidden to send the people back to Egypt, and woe to those who go down for help

³⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [James 1:26](#) • [Hebrews 3:13](#) - a heart deceived by its own religion, and the hardening that comes by the deceitfulness of sin

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 40-42

- Freedom offered and comfort declined - a prophet choosing rubble over imperial patronage
- Accurate theology from an unexpected mouth, and the shame of an outsider saying it better
- The brief, real restoration that ordinary obedience produced at Mizpah
- Goodness without discernment: a credible warning treated as slander, and a remnant scattered for it
- Hospitality violated, grief counterfeited, and infrastructure built for life turned to a grave
- Fear of consequences never verified, driving a people toward the one place they were forbidden
- A model prayer for guidance offered by people who had already decided
- Ten days of silence as part of the answer, and what waiting exposes in us
- A God who says He grieves over the distress He Himself brought
- Mercy promised inside an enemy's heart, and safety located in the frightening option
- Self-deception named for what it is - dealing deceitfully against our own souls

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who set the whole land before Jeremiah and let him choose find us willing to stay where He has placed us, even when an easier country is offered.

May we never need a foreigner to explain to us what God has been saying to us for years.

May He give us discernment that does not curdle into suspicion, and trust that still posts a watch.

May we be people whose grief is real and whose kindness is not a tactic, and may we never use another person's sorrow to get through their gate.

May we ask Him for direction with the question genuinely open, and may our "whether it is good or bad, we will obey" still be standing ten days later.

May we wait through His silences without quietly making up our minds.

And when He tells us to stay in the hard place and promises to build and plant us there, may we believe that the safety we imagine elsewhere is the very danger He is warning us about.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.